Sleep and memory

Sleep does more than rest the body. While you sleep, the brain replays the day and moves new information from short-term storage in the hippocampus to longer-term storage in the cortex.

Deep sleep appears to help with facts and events, and REM sleep with skills and emotional memories. People who sleep after learning remember more the next day than people who stay awake for the same hours. Missing sleep before learning also makes it harder to take in new information in the first place.

Most adults need seven to nine hours. A regular bedtime, a dark and cool room, and no caffeine in the afternoon all help. A short nap of about twenty minutes can improve alertness without leaving you groggy.

This is why an all-night study session usually backfires. It is better to study in shorter blocks across several days and sleep in between.